being conducted to arrest the suspects. At last count, 124 arrests had been made in Nuh and Gurugram. Chief minister Manohar Lal Khattar sniffs a deeper (read, political) conspiracy in these acts of violence in what he called an otherwise "peaceful" region. VHP joint general secretary Surendra Jain too claimed the attacks against Hindu devotees were carried out "in a pre-planned manner", "incited" by some Congress leaders in Haryana. Former Congress chief minister Bhupinder Singh Hooda rubbished the charge, accusing the BJP regime of not acting on prior intelligence on the chances of violence. He claimed Mewat—the larger Muslim-dominated region straddling parts of south Haryana and eastern Rajasthan within which Nuh falls—had not witnessed violence on such a scale even during the Partition.

According to the Hindu ritual calendar, each Monday of the month of Shravan (falling in July-August) is to be marked by a special puja of Lord Shiva. This was the third Monday. The VHP had planned a yatra to the Shiva temple in Nuh town, with the permission of the local administration. Its call triggered tensions, with Muslim groups raising a red flag over a video of Monu Manesar—a cow vigilante booked for the murder of two Muslim men, whose charred bodies were found in Bhiwani district in February. In the video, Monu declared he would join the yatra and threw down a dare to local Muslims to try stop him, also soliciting mass participation in pujas at Shiva temples across the district. Muslim groups in turn dared him to visit Nuh. Monu finally skipped the event. Sources attribute his retreat to local VHP leaders, who advised Monu against any misadventure so as to avoid tensions.

But the damage was already done. Just when devotees were leaving the temple after morning rituals, a mob attacked them. Muslim groups blame VHP and Bajrang Dal groups for raising provocative slogans while passing through areas dominated by the minorities. VHP leaders say only purely religious or patriotic slogans were raised. Union minister and Gurgaon MP Rao Inderjit Singh entered a critical note, wondering "who had given weapons" to the yatris. While not absolving the attackers, he asked: "Who goes to a religious procession carrying swords, or sticks? This is wrong. A provocation may have taken place from this side too." VHP leaders say the sword and sticks were symbolic, and counter that the attackers used stones, swords, firearms and even "sophisticated weapons". They even termed it a "terror attack", demanding a probe by the National Investigation Agency. For now, Haryana Police is investigating the whole sequence of events.

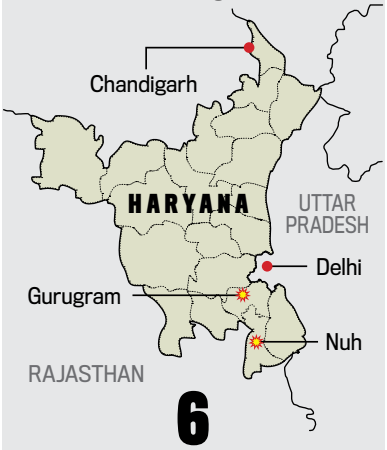
Whatever the investigation reveals, its trigger and the impact are quite unambiguous. Nuh is the only Muslim-majority district in Haryana, with the community accounting for 80 per cent of its 1.1 million-strong population (as per the 2011 census). The majority of them are Meo Muslims, an ethnic group spread across Mewat—a region that has been ground zero for communal tensions, especially on the issues of cow slaughter, 'love jihad' and the contentious Citizenship (Amendment) Act.

The Nuh violence is likely to bleed into the poll campaign in Rajasthan. The seven adjoining districts of the state—Alwar, Bharatpur, Dholpur, Tonk, Karauli, Sawai Madhopur and Dausa—send 39 MLAs to the 200-strong assembly and elect five of the state's 25 MPs. The polarisation will also help the ruling BJP in west UP, where Jayant Chaudhary's Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD) is trying to stitch together Jat unity.

But there's more to it. The VHP and Bajrang Dal are upset with the Khattar regime and, in private, they too speak of an "intelligence failure". Jain is even provoking Khattar into taking stern action against the rioters. "If Haryana doesn't have bulldozers, they can take it on loan from UP," he suggested. By August 2, the Supreme Court had stepped in, issuing notices to Haryana, UP and Delhi, besides directing the Centre to ensure no hate speech or violence takes place in Delhi-NCR. But anger may be just one video away. ■

THE FALLOUT

...of the July 31-Aug. 1 communal clashes in Nuh and Gurugram



6
DEAD, INCLUDING 2 HOME GUARDS

44
FIRs REGISTERED

100+
INJURED

124
ARRESTED

THE NUH VIOLENCE IS LIKELY TO BLEED RIGHT INTO THE POLL CAMPAIGNING IN NEIGHBOURING RAJASTHAN